

STORAGE SEES MANY INNOVATIONS

Storage is no longer a mere device. It is a 'solution' comprising hardware and software, and both spaces have their share of innovations



Transcend StoreJet 18M

■ **JANANI GOPALAKRISHNAN VIKRAM
WITH INPUTS FROM ONKAR SHARMA**

In the early days of computing, if you wanted to store as much information, pictures, music and videos as you do today, you would have needed a hard drive as big as your room. Today you can store it in a thumb-sized drive! Earlier, companies could have not imagined storing as much operational data as they do now, let alone archive information for statistical analysis, forecasting and compliance. Yet, today they can store all this and still have space for more.

The storage technology has developed significantly in the past decade—

iPods, mobile phones and ultra-mobile PCs on the personal storage front, with highly-energy-efficient and intelligent network storage devices and blade servers on the enterprise front.

Vik Mahadevan, vice president-product marketing and management, Engenio Storage Group, LSI, comments, "We think that innovations exist at all levels of storage—from personal devices to direct attached storage, to shared storage."

However, the nature and degree of innovation at each level varies, as these two markets are quite different from each other. "The factors for personal storage consist of 3Ps, which stands for price, portability and performance,

whereas the most important factor in the enterprise storage is the consistency of data," explains Darshan Joshi, vice president-storage and availability Engineering Group, Symantec.

Let us take a look at some of the recent innovations and trends in storage.

Disks are shrinking

Disks are becoming smaller and smaller. Transcend recently introduced a new hard disk drive, the 18M StoreJet, with a capacity of 120 gigabytes (GB) and measuring around 4.6 cm along the sides.

"While 60 GB was the mainstream three years ago, now we already have 1.5 terabyte (TB) storage devices. The size has gone down from 8.9cm to 6.3cm, to 4.6cm (3.5" to 2.5," to 1.8"). Now, we are trying to change from disk reading (traditional hard disk drives) to flash chips (solid-state drives)," says Austin Huang, regional head-sales, SAARC & APAC, Transcend India.

Sound technology

Solid-state devices (SSD) are the 'in' thing in the storage space now.

In October, Intel released an SSD toolbox along with an SSD optimiser to help developers monitor and make the most of their Intel-based solid-state drives.

In November, Verbatim announced its ExpressCard SSD for PC and Mac users. It is a solid-state drive that provides ExpressCard slot-equipped XP/Vista PCs and OS X-equipped Macs with plug-in storage that is up to five times faster than the USB-based ExpressCards. They promise reading